

PEOPLES OF ASIA I

OF ALL THE CONTINENTS, Asia has the largest population with the greatest variety of cultures. The history of civilization here stretches back for many thousands of years. Cities and writing, the development of which are closely connected, first appeared in Asia. More than 5,000 years ago the earliest cities, such as Babylon, emerged in the valley of the Tigris and Euphrates rivers, an area known as Mesopotamia (modern-day Iraq). Today, Asia contains over 60 percent of the world's population, much of which is concentrated in the southern and eastern regions of the continent. Although most of the people are farmers, city populations are growing very rapidly.



Stone reliefs in Persepolis, capital of the ancient Persian Empire

EARLY CIVILIZATIONS

The world's earliest civilizations grew up around river valleys in Asia in an area known as the fertile crescent, which stretches in an arc from the Persian Gulf to the Mediterranean Sea. Many cities here can trace their history back for several thousand years.

